
PROPOSAL FOR STUDENT INNOVATION CENTER WEBSITE

Date: March 30, 2026

To: Student Innovation Center Administration and Iowa State University IT Staff

From: Mubina Sadriddinova, Undergraduate Cybersecurity Engineering Student at Iowa State University

Re: Proposal for a Usability Study of the Student Innovation Center Scheduling Website

PURPOSE

The purpose of this document is to propose a usability study of the Student Innovation Center Scheduling website in order to improve clarity, efficiency, and ease of use for student reservations. This study would help the Student Innovation Center and Iowa State University staff better understand where students experience confusion and how the reservation process can be improved, while reducing the amount of work and misunderstanding between staff and students.

SUMMARY

The Student Innovation Center is an important part of student life at Iowa State University. The center describes itself as a place for creativity and collaboration and states that students can reserve private meeting rooms, event spaces, and classrooms. Because the reservation system supports academic work, meetings, and campus activities, it is important that students can use it easily and correctly.

At the same time, the reservation process includes several rules and pathways that may be difficult for some users to understand quickly. For example, the official reservation pages explain that standard meeting rooms can be reserved for up to three hours per day and open 30 days out, while large conference rooms open five days out and may require a different process for reservations further in advance. The site also explains that some spaces must be reserved through other offices and that reservations are not guaranteed. These details are important, but they can also increase user confusion if the process is not immediately clear.

This proposal recommends a small usability study focused on common student tasks. The study would ask students to complete tasks such as reserving a room, locating reservation rules, and identifying the correct path for different types of spaces. The study would use observation, think-aloud testing, time-on-task measurement, and short post-test questions. Usability

guidance from Digital.gov explains that usability is measured by how easily people can accomplish their goals, often using methods such as success rates and satisfaction. Nielsen Norman Group also recommends small qualitative tests and notes that five participants are often enough to uncover the most common usability problems in a single user group.

The proposed study would be affordable, realistic, and useful. It would provide the Student Innovation Center and university staff with direct evidence of where students struggle, what tasks take too long, and what changes would likely improve the experience. The final result would be a written report with findings, screenshots, task outcomes, and clear recommendations for improvement.

INTRODUCTION

The Student Innovation Center Scheduling website deserves attention because it supports a high-value student service. Iowa State's Student Innovation Center presents itself as a welcoming place for students of all majors and highlights room reservations as one of its main services, it is one of the most welcoming buildings for all majors and has been considered as the best building on campus in 2022. Students often need to reserve a room quickly for class projects, meetings, events, or study sessions. When the website is not clear, students can waste time, make mistakes, or use the wrong process. A better website would help students complete their tasks more easily and would also reduce avoidable questions for staff.

This also matters because the Student Innovation Center is still a major and fairly new university investment. Iowa State says the Student Innovation Center is a five-level, 140,000-square-foot building, and university sources describe it as an **\$84 million project** supported by major private gifts and a **\$40 million state investment**. When a university invests this much into a building, it should also make sure students can fully use it without confusion. The website should match the quality of the building itself.

A better website also helps the university in the bigger picture. Colleges care about student experience, enrollment, public image, and reputation. National Student Clearinghouse data show that U.S. postsecondary enrollment was over **19.4 million** in fall 2025 and public four-year institutions saw growth, which means schools are still competing for students. A clear and professional reservation system can support student satisfaction and make Iowa State look more organized and student-friendly.

BACKGROUND AND NEED

The Student Innovation Center website explains that students can reserve different types of spaces, but the process is not always simple. Standard meeting rooms, large conference rooms, classrooms, and event spaces do not all follow the same rules. Some rooms open at different times, some have time limits, some are not guaranteed, and some spaces must be reserved through another office. This means students need to understand several rules before they can finish one task.

The problem is not that the website has no information. The problem is that students may have trouble finding the right information fast enough and understanding what to do next. This is why a usability study is a good choice. It can show exactly where students stop, hesitate, misunderstand something, or choose the wrong path.

This is also important because universities want to stay strong in enrollment and student satisfaction. If Iowa State has a modern and expensive center, then the online process connected to that center should also feel modern, clear, and easy. A confusing process can weaken the student experience, while a simple process can make the university look better and work better.

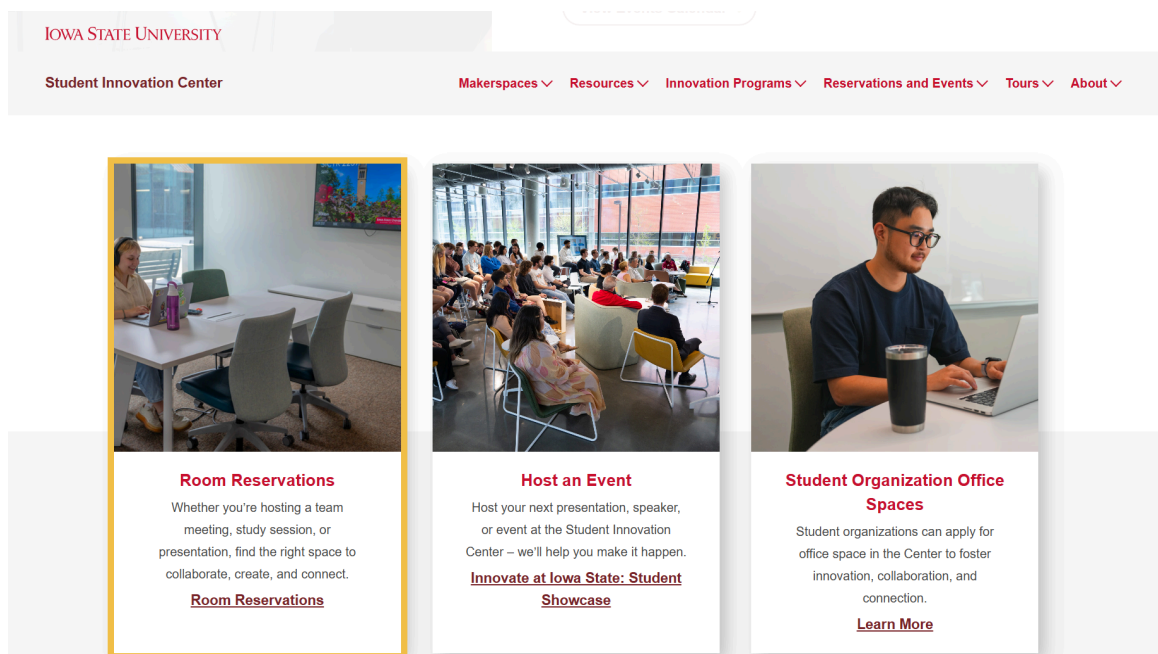


Figure 1. Student Innovation Center homepage. This figure shows that room reservations are a major service presented to students.

Meet, exhibit, present, study, and more

Room reservations are open to all Iowa State students, faculty and staff.



Standard meeting rooms

Standard meeting rooms can accommodate up to 10 people and can be reserved for up to three hours per day. Reservations open 30 days out.

Reserve a room →



Host an event

Planning an event? Need to reserve a large conference room more than five days in advance? Fill out an event request form.

Make a request →



General university classrooms

General university classrooms — including an auditorium, learning-in-the-round classroom, team-based learning classroom, large capacity classroom, and medium capacity classroom — must be reserved through Facilities Planning and Management.

Go to FPM room scheduling →

Figure 2. Room Reservations page. This figure shows that the website includes multiple room types, time limits, and reservation rules that users must understand.

PROPOSED TASKS (SOMETIMES “PLAN OF WORK”)

This usability study will focus on common student tasks. It will measure whether students can complete these tasks successfully, how long the tasks take, what mistakes happen, and what students say during and after the test. The study will use a small group of students because a small usability test can still reveal common problems clearly and quickly.

The study will include **5 to 8 students**. It should include both students who have used the website before and students who have not. This mix will help show whether the website works for both experienced and first-time users.

Task 1: Define Study Goals and Success Measures

The first task is to define what the study is measuring. Based on usability guidance, the main measures should include task success, time on task, common errors, and participant feedback. These measures will show whether students can complete important reservation tasks efficiently and correctly.

Task 2: Recruit Participants

The second task is to recruit five to eight student participants. Nielsen Norman Group recommends about five participants for a typical qualitative usability study of one user group because this number can uncover many of the most common problems without making the study too expensive or difficult to manage. To strengthen the results, participants should include both students who have used the site before and first-time or less experienced users.

Task 3: Prepare Realistic Test Scenarios

The third task is to prepare realistic tasks that reflect what students actually need to do. These tasks may include:

1. Reserve a standard meeting room for a small group project.
2. Find out how to reserve a large conference room.
3. Determine whether a classroom can be reserved through the Student Innovation Center or through another office.
4. Find the reservation rules for length of use and availability.
5. Locate the correct form for hosting an event.

These scenarios are appropriate because they match the options and rules presented on the official Student Innovation Center reservation pages.

Task 4: Conduct Moderated Think-Aloud Sessions

The fourth task is to run moderated usability sessions. Each participant will complete the same set of tasks while speaking aloud about what they are thinking. Nielsen Norman Group describes think-aloud testing as one of the most valuable usability methods because it reveals confusion, expectations, and decision-making in real time. During each session, the facilitator will observe behavior, record errors, and note points where participants hesitate or become uncertain.

Task 5: Analyze Findings

The fifth task is to analyze the results. This analysis will focus on patterns, such as which tasks had the lowest success rate, which pages caused the most hesitation, and which rules or labels participants misunderstood. Time on task will help show where students lose efficiency, while post-test comments will help explain why those problems happened.

Task 6: Prepare the Final Report

The final task is to produce a short professional report for the Student Innovation Center administration and IT staff. The report will include the study purpose, participant group, test tasks, findings, screenshots, and recommendations. Recommendations may include simplifying wording, improving navigation labels, clarifying differences between reservation types, or making rules easier to find before students begin the reservation process.

Questions to Ask Participants

To make the study stronger, the researcher should ask a few simple questions before, during, and after the tasks.

Background questions

- Have you used this website before?
- What kind of room do you expect to reserve here?
- How confident do you feel using university websites like this?

Task questions

- Show me how you would reserve a meeting room.
- Where would you go for a large conference room?
- How would you find the room rules?

- How would you know if another office handles the room?

Think-aloud questions

- What are you thinking right now?
- Why did you click that?
- Is anything here confusing?
- What did you expect to see?

Post-test questions

- Which task was easiest?
- Which task was hardest?
- What was hard to find?
- What should be changed first?

These questions are helpful because they show not only what students do, but also why they do it.

Diagram

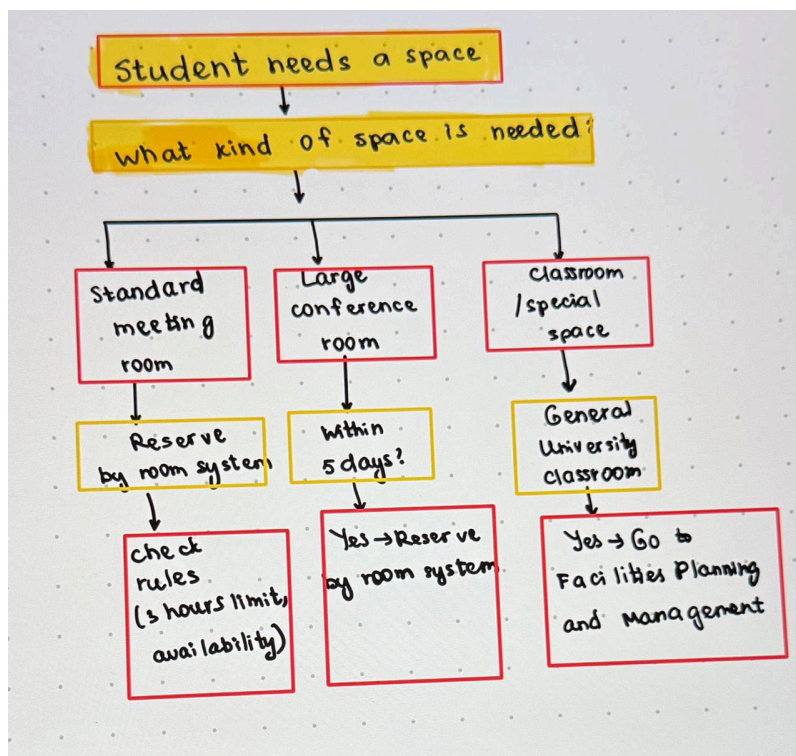


Figure 3. Proposed reservation path

Schedule

This study will be completed during **Summer 2026**. Doing the study in summer is realistic because it gives enough time to plan the sessions carefully, recruit students, collect feedback, and finish the report before heavy fall-semester use begins.

Time	Activity	Main Responsibility
Late May 2026	Finalize study goals, success measures, task list, and consent language	Student researcher
Early June 2026	Recruit 5–8 students and prepare test materials	Student researcher
Mid June 2026	Pilot the study and revise any unclear tasks or instructions	Student researcher
Late June to Mid July 2026	Conduct moderated think-aloud usability sessions and collect notes, timings, and feedback	Student researcher
Late July 2026	Organize findings, identify patterns, and compare task success and common errors	Student researcher
Early August 2026	Write the final report with screenshots, diagram, findings, and recommendations	Student researcher

Table 1. Proposed Summer 2026 timeline for the usability study

This schedule is realistic because the study is small, focused, and qualitative. It does not require software development or a large research team. It mainly requires planning, observation, and analysis, which makes it practical for an early-stage university usability study. Nielsen Norman Group also notes that small qualitative tests are efficient and cost-effective for identifying common usability issues

BUDGET

This proposal does not require a large budget. Most of the work can be completed with basic tools and student participation. Because this is a small usability study, the cost is modest.

Item	Estimated Cost
5 participant gift cards at \$10 each	\$50
Printing and study materials	\$10
Data organization and report preparation	\$15
Contingency	\$15
Total	\$90

Table 2. Estimated budget for the usability study.

This budget is intentionally conservative. If incentives are not used, the cost could be even lower. The proposal therefore offers a strong benefit-to-cost ratio: for a relatively small amount, the Student Innovation Center could gain direct evidence about student confusion and specific guidance for improving the reservation experience. Small studies are especially appropriate when the goal is to identify practical usability issues early and efficiently.

EXPERIENCE

I am an Iowa State University student and a member of the same user community that relies on university systems for academic and organizational tasks. This perspective is useful because students are the primary audience for the reservation website, and student experience is central to evaluating whether the site is easy to use. I understand the importance of completing tasks quickly and correctly, especially when students are balancing classes, group work, deadlines, and campus involvement.

Although I am not presenting myself as a professional UX consultant, I am proposing a realistic student-centered study that uses well-established usability methods. My role is to identify the problem, apply an appropriate testing approach, and communicate findings in a clear and useful way to the campus audience that can act on them.

CONCLUSION

The Student Innovation Center reservation system supports important student work, but its official pages show that the process includes several room types, rules, and reservation paths that may not be immediately clear to all users. When students cannot easily tell where to click, which form to use, or what rules apply, the result can be frustration, wasted time, and preventable mistakes.

A usability study is an appropriate response because it will measure whether users can complete their goals easily and effectively. By using task-based testing, think-aloud sessions, time-on-task measurement, and participant feedback, the Student Innovation Center and Iowa State IT staff can gather direct evidence about how the reservation experience works in practice.

For these reasons, I respectfully recommend approval of this usability study. The study is affordable, manageable, and likely to produce practical recommendations that improve the reservation experience for students while also supporting staff efficiency and service quality.

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